Healing Begins by Slowing Down the Mind

Is Watching a Video Really Rest? Can it Calm the Mind?

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प्रशाम्यत्यौषधैः पूर्वो दैवयुक्तिव्यपाश्रयैः। मानसो ज्ञानविज्ञानधैर्यस्मृतिसमाधिभिः॥

--- चरकसंहिता सूत्रस्थान (१.५८)

समाधिः विषयेभ्यो निवर्त्यात्मनि मनसो नियमनम् ।

--- चरकसंहिता आयुर्वेददीपिका व्याख्या

*The bodily disorders are pacified through medicines and the appropriate therapeutic approaches, whereas **mental disorders are pacified through knowledge, discrimination, steadiness, memory and samādhi**. (Samādhi is described as withdrawing the mind from its objects and regulating/directing it toward the Self.)*

A Matter-of-fact Answer

During one of my Āyurveda lectures, while discussing how healing begins with the slowing down of the mind, I posed a simple question to the class:

Is there any one activity in your life that you do with complete focus and calmness, without any wandering thoughts?

Most of the class really did not have an answer. They seemed to admit that our lives have been divested of this unique human faculty. One brave response, though, stood out - "Watching movies."
It made me smile and ponder with deep amusement, not because it was incorrect, but because it was honest. Many students genuinely feel absorbed while watching a movie, so it appears to fit the idea of focus.
From an Āyurvedic perspective, however, this moment opens an important doorway for deeper understanding.

Concentration Does Not Necessarily Mean Mental Calm

There is essentially a distinction between focus and calm. A mind can be intensely focused and yet remain physiologically and psychologically unsettled. Āyurveda points toward a subtle distinction between concentration and mental regulation. A mind may be capable of directing its attention toward a single object, yet true mental well-being requires something more - steadiness (*dhairya*), restraint (*manonigraha*), and regulation of the mind (*samādhi*). Thus, mental healing is not merely about making the mind focused; it is about making it steady, regulated, and free from disturbing movements. Modern neuroscience supports this distinction. Research on screen exposure consistently shows that visually engaging content demands continuous top-down attention, rapid sensory processing, and emotional reactivity (For e.g. see, Oswald et al. 2023). Even when attention feels unified, the nervous system remains in a state of alert engagement rather than restoration.

When watching a movie, the mind is not necessarily resting - it is being fed continuously. Rapid scene changes, loud auditory cues, background music, dialogue, emotional triggers, suspense, fear, excitement, and desire keep the brain actively responding. Studies examining screen time show that such stimulation depletes cognitive resources required for emotion regulation, including sustained attention and inhibitory control. This depletion may not be consciously felt in the moment, but it becomes evident afterward as fatigue, dullness, irritability, or restlessness.

Exhaustion and rest are not the same. A mind that collapses into blankness after prolonged stimulation has not healed - it has simply run out of energy. Modern research echoes this insight. Experimental research suggests that natural environments can support attentional restoration, while continued engagement with electronic devices can interfere with this restorative effect (Jiang etal. 2019). In fact, even brief exposure to natural environments initiates attentional restoration and stress reduction. This occurs because natural stimuli engage the mind effortlessly rather than demand continuous cognitive control. This distinction explains why the body feels different after a quiet walk outdoors compared to watching multiple episodes of a series. One leaves the nervous system settled and coherent, while the other often leaves it fragmented. Āyurveda places great emphasis on this settling of internal movement because when the mind slows down, it no longer drags the body into instability. The body then remains rooted in the present moment, allowing digestion, circulation, sleep, and repair mechanisms to function optimally. Research on mindfulness suggests that practices involving sustained but non-reactive attention can reduce perceived stress and support emotional regulation (Khoury et al., 2015). Neurobiological research has also associated mindfulness practice with changes in brain systems involved in attention, emotion regulation and stress processing (Tang et al., 2015). Experimental work on body-scan meditation has reported short-term changes in autonomic and cardiovascular measures (Ditto et al., 2006). Importantly, these benefits arise not from intense concentration but from reduced mental noise and sensory load.

Tiger vs. Cow

An analogy may help clarify this difference. A tiger sitting motionless before a hunt appears still, yet internally it is highly activated. A cow sitting quietly while chewing cud is still both outwardly and inwardly. Watching an intensely stimulating movie can resemble the stillness of the tiger - outwardly still but internally charged. Practices such as slow walking, mindful eating, gentle breathing, oil massage, or quiet sitting resemble the stillness of the cow - calm without inner turbulence. Research on mindfulness consistently shows that such states are associated with lower emotional reactivity and improved psychological well-being.

The intention behind the classroom question, therefore, was not to identify moments when the world disappears, but to invite reflection on moments when the nervous system truly slows down. Healing activities are those that reduce speed, noise, sensory overload, and constant reaction. They allow the mind to settle naturally rather than hold it captive through stimulation. The student's answer was honest, and that honesty is valuable. It reflects a deeper reality of modern life - that constant stimulation has become so familiar that it begins to feel like peace. Scientific literature increasingly warns that this confusion comes at a cost. Excessive screen exposure is associated with increased anxiety, sleep disturbance, attentional fatigue, and emotional dysregulation, especially among young people (Benvin 2025, Oswald et al. 2023). Āyurveda articulated a concern with mental disturbance, sensory excess and loss of mental regulation long before the modern problem of digital overstimulation emerged. It taught that health is not merely the absence of disease, but the presence of rhythm, stillness, and coherence within the mind and body. Recognizing the difference between stimulation and calm is not a mistake - it is the beginning of awareness. And awareness, in both Āyurveda and modern science, is where healing truly begins.

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